EvenOut

hey, vans!
welcome back
Who Pays Whom
You borrowed
₹350
You lent
₹430
Home
History
Groups
Profile

Project Brief

EvenOut is a UX case study exploring the "social cost of debt" — the emotional friction that arises when friends borrow and lend money.

While payment apps have made transactions seamless, they have not solved the awkwardness of asking for repayment. This project investigates how design can reduce emotional load, protect friendships, and remove the hesitation around shared expenses.

Is there a way to solve this problem?

Audience: Gen Z & Young Millennials (18–28)
Goal: Eliminate the emotional burden of asking for money

A problem that's evident, yet there's no concrete solution!

Research

Demographics: **18- 22 years**

Through early research, one thing became clear:
It's not that people can't send money.
It's that they don't want to ask for it.

- Qualitative interviews
- Quantitative survey
- Sentence completion

Research Insights

01

Trust > Amount

The relationship (close friend vs. acquaintance) dictates all lending rules, not the dollar amount.

02

Social fear > Financial loss

Lenders fear being seen as "petty" or "calculative" more than they fear losing the money.

03

Friendship > Debt

Debtors are driven by guilt and the fear of damaging the friendship, not the financial cost.

04

"Awkwardness tax"

Users "pay" a tax by letting small amounts (the "hassle threshold") slide just to avoid the awkwardness of asking and the burden of monitoring.

05

The outlier

A minority feels zero awkwardness, proving a purely transactional, "frictionless" state is possible.

Quantitative surveys

34 participants

17 males

17 females

The user surveys helped us understand various factors such as financial thresholds, emotional barrier, social dynamic and the core trade-off that affect emotions.

25/34

Pay on behalf of friends **at least once a week**

27/34

Users influenced by the fear of **seeming "petty"**.

25/34

Users citing **"losing the friendship"** as their primary worry.

21/34

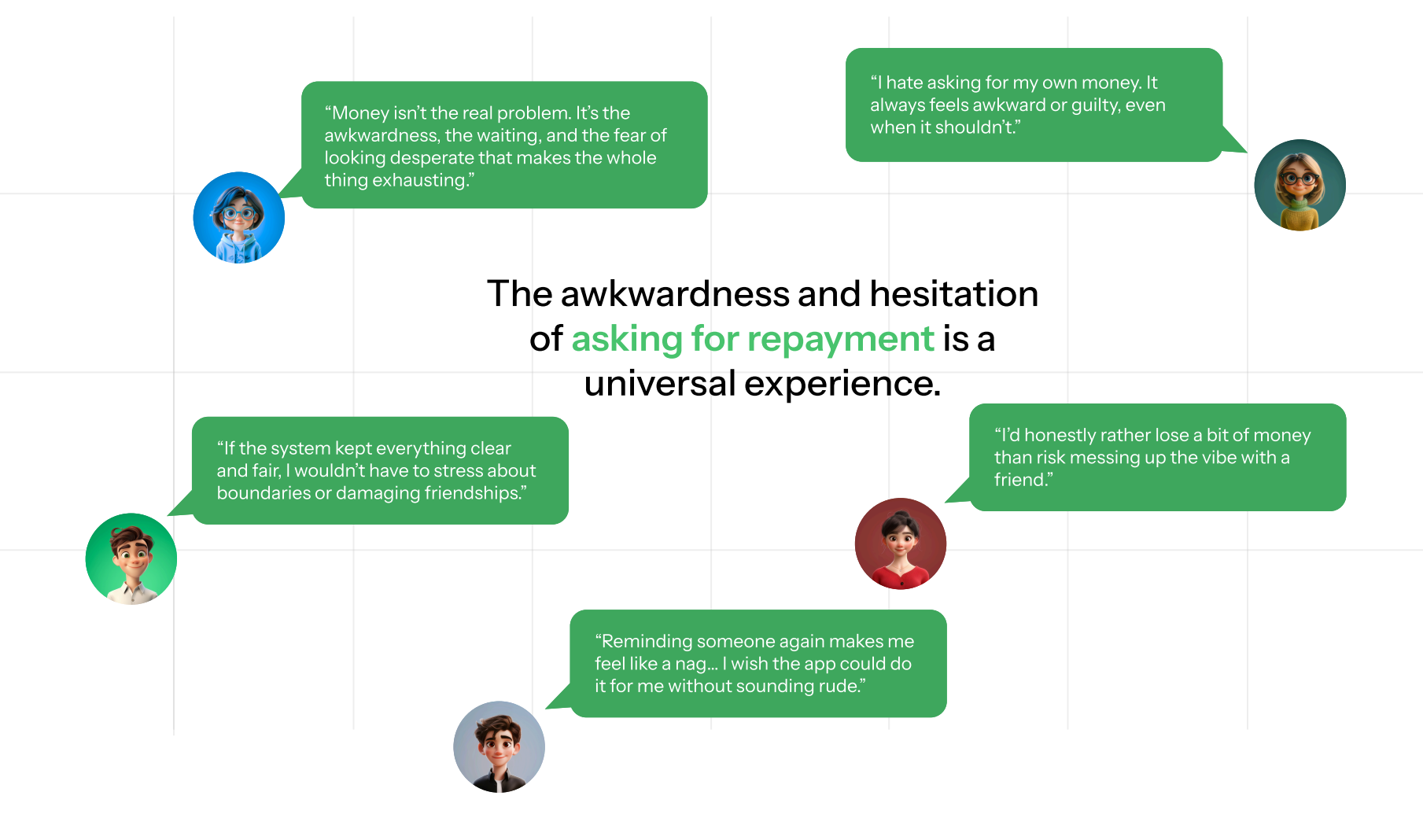
Feel **anxious** to **initiate a request** for money owed.

26/34

Feel **comfortable asking a close friend** for repayment rather than an acquaintance.

21/34

Users explicitly **want an app** to handle the **"nagging"** and depersonalize the request.



"Money isn't the real problem. It's the awkwardness, the waiting, and the fear of looking desperate that makes the whole thing exhausting."

"I hate asking for my own money. It always feels awkward or guilty, even when it shouldn't."

The awkwardness and hesitation of asking for repayment is a universal experience.

"If the system kept everything clear and fair, I wouldn't have to stress about boundaries or damaging friendships."

"I'd honestly rather lose a bit of money than risk messing up the vibe with a friend."

"Reminding someone again makes me feel like a nag... I wish the app could do it for me without sounding rude."

Reframing the Question

Instead of asking

"How do we help users track money better?"

We reframed it to

"How might we remove the emotional responsibility of asking for money altogether?"

Design Frameworks

To translate research insights into a meaningful solution, we used three strategic frameworks to define the problem space, user value, and design direction.

Worth Map

The Worth Map was used to understand what users truly value beyond functionality.
It mapped:

- User pains (guilt, fear of judgment, social tension)
- Benefits (emotional relief, trust, financial clarity)
- Experience goals (stress-free and predictable repayment)

This shifted the design focus from efficiency to emotional comfort and social harmony.

Value Proposition

The Value Proposition connected user problems with product features.
It helped define how EvenOut:

- Eliminates the need to "beg" for repayment
- Reduces mental load through automated tracking
- Protects social image with non-confrontational communication
- Enables clear and fair financial interactions

This ensured every feature addressed a real user pain.

Design Arena

The Design Arena helped identify where the solution creates impact by mapping:

- Purpose: Reduce emotional friction in financial interactions
- Beneficiaries: Lenders, borrowers, and social groups sharing expenses
- Context: Social relationships, shared expenses, and digital payment systems

This framework ensured the design focused on protecting relationships — not just enabling transactions.

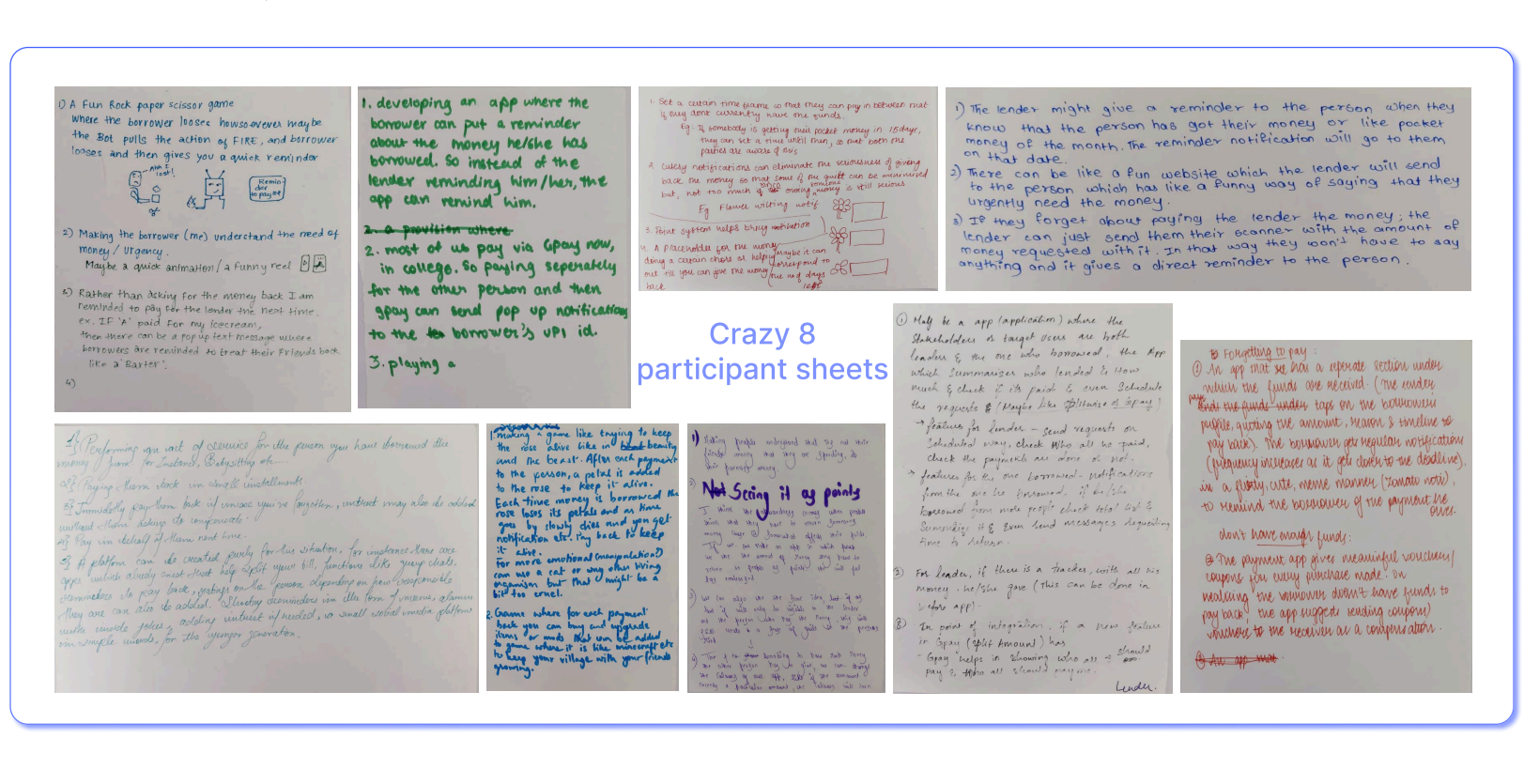
Ideation method: Co-Design

To ensure our solution addressed the deep emotional friction identified in our research, we utilised a rapid Co-Design session with 9 users, combining two powerful methods:

- Reverse brainstorming
- Crazy 8's

Outcome:

- This method ensured our design decisions were immediately validated by user pain points.
- Some fantastic, out-of-the-box ideas were born!



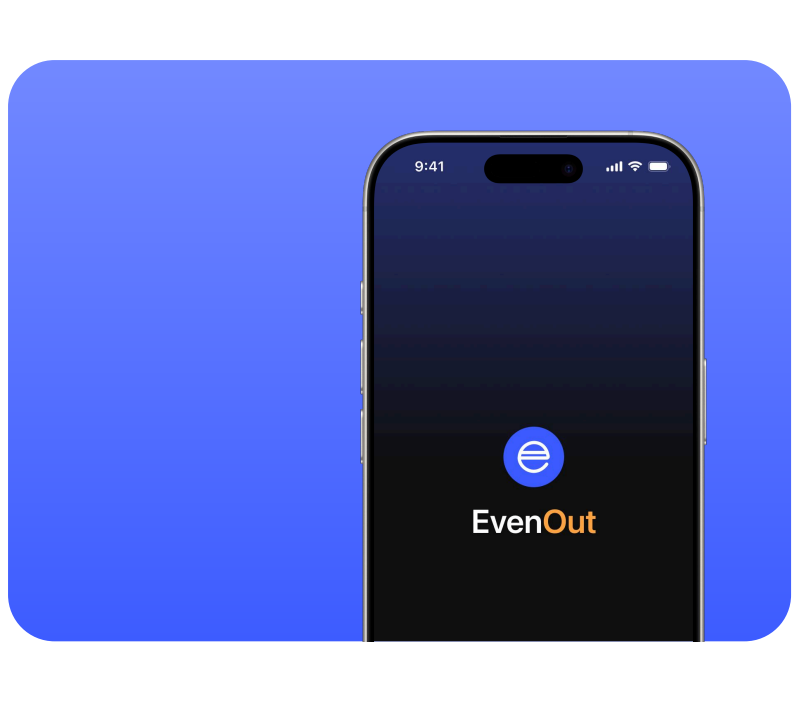
Crazy 8 participant sheets

Final ideas

From the co-design activity, we consolidated the most relevant ideas into potential app features.
Here are the concepts that best fit our use case:

Context based notifications	flirty, funny, friendly- like Swiggy, Zomato
Scheduled payment timeline	according to the comforts of both parties
Fun Reminders	memes or inside jokes as reminders
Gamified countdown	options like lego, wilting rose, superheroes, etc. to choose from
Tailored notifications	select the style of notifications for sending
Home page gamification	home page gamifies according to the theme chosen
Profile changes	profile character changes moods complying to the payment timeline
Notification frequency	frequency increases as deadline approaches

Proposed Solution


9:41
EvenOut

EvenOut removes the social awkwardness of asking friends for money. It automates tracking and reminders, acting as a neutral middleman so young adults can settle small debts without tension.

Who is this for?

EvenOut is built for Gen Z and young Millennials *(ages 18–28)*- the "digital native" generation that lives socially but struggles financially.

Why them?

They're connected, conflict-averse, and prefer gamified digital solutions that maintain social harmony.

University students

Managing tight allowances, hostel canteens, and group projects.

Roommates and flatmates

Young professionals living in shared apartments (PGs) who split rent, groceries, and utilities daily.

Friend groups

Friend groups who frequently dine out, travel together, or split ride-shares (Uber/Ola).

A/B User Testing

To measure which design philosophy (Worth Focused Design or User Centred Design) more effectively reduces the Social Cost of Debt.

Task : Send a reminder to Mehansh

10 participants

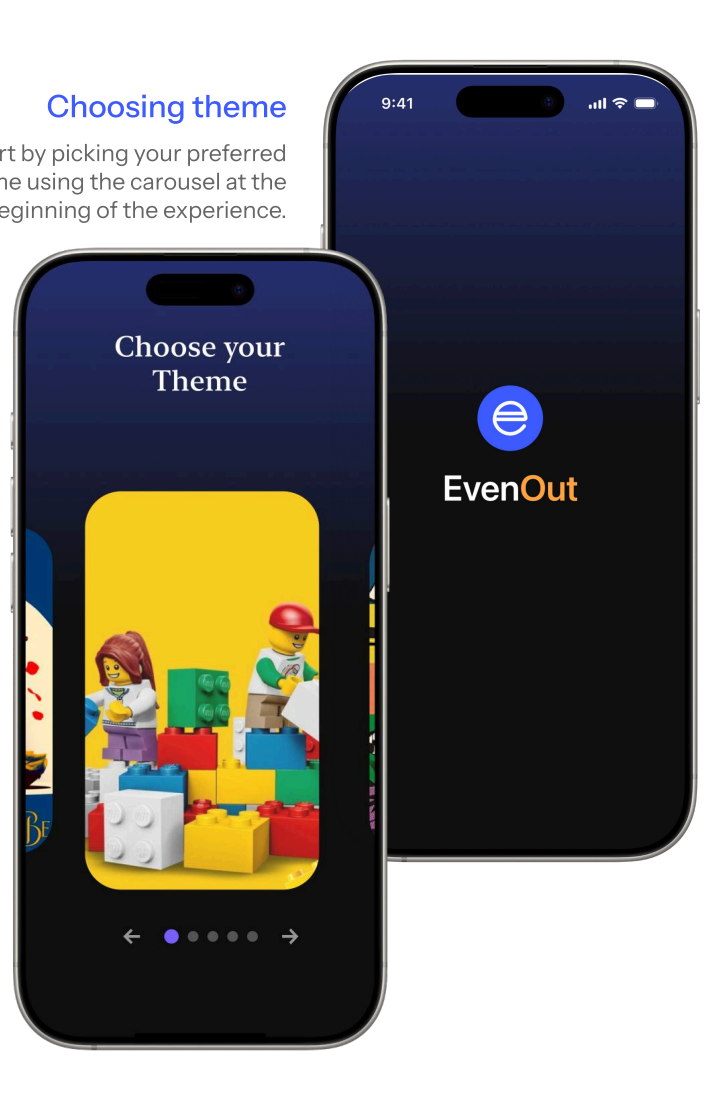
5 WFD Interface

5 UCD Interface

Worth Focused Interface *(EvenOut)*

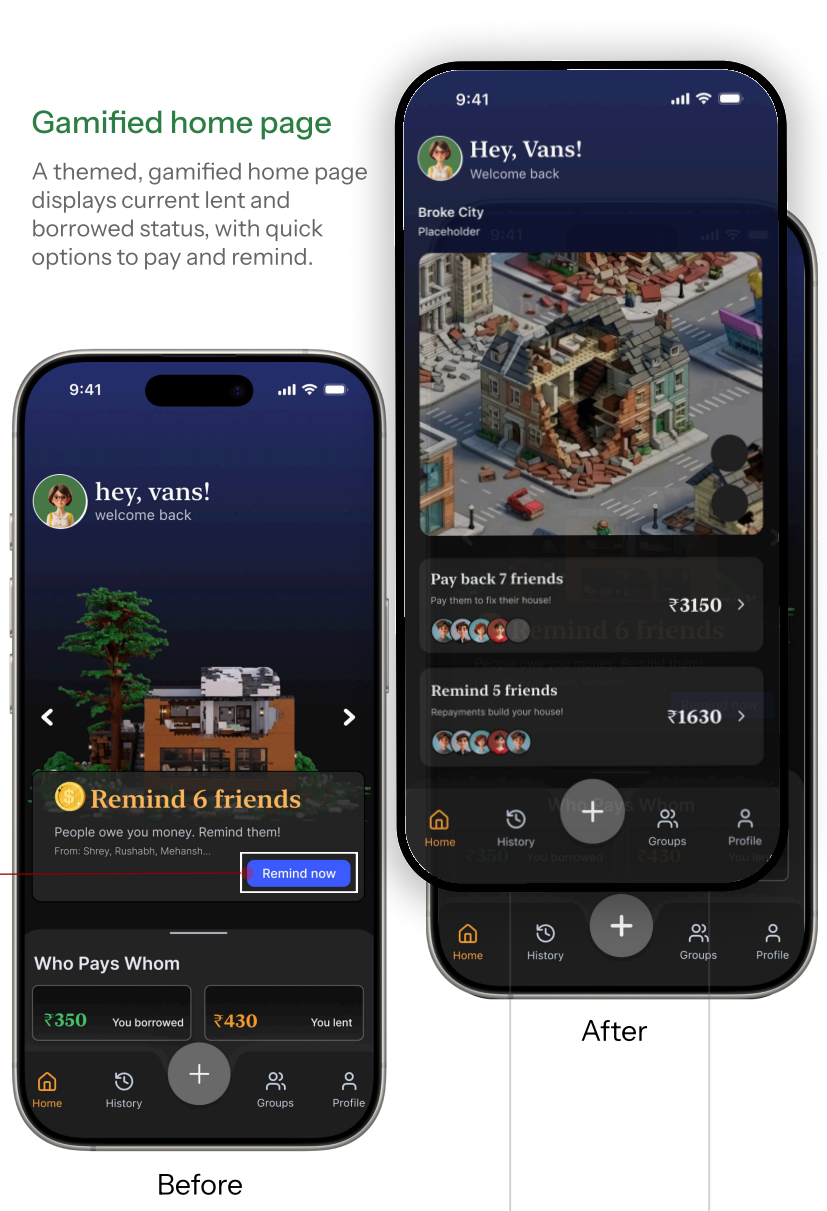
Choosing theme

Start by picking your preferred theme using the carousel at the beginning of the experience.


Choose your Theme
9:41
EvenOut

Gamified home page

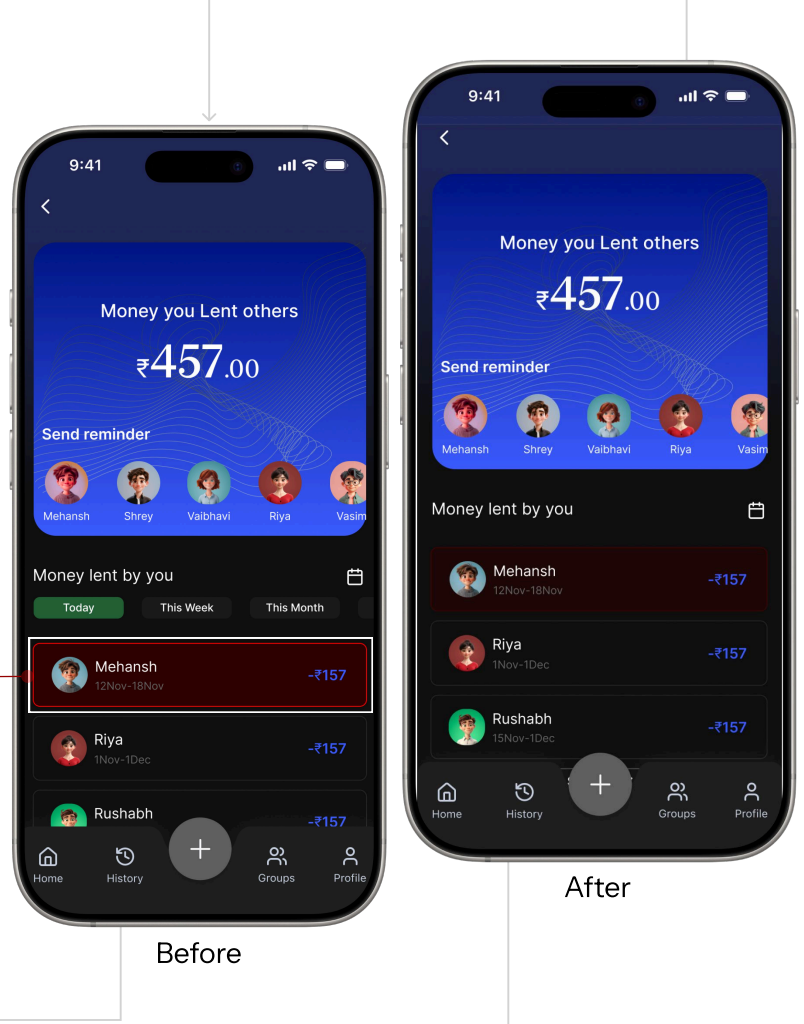
A themed, gamified home page displays current lent and borrowed status, with quick options to pay and remind.


hey, vans!
welcome back
Remind 6 friends
People owe you money. Remind them!
Remind now
Who Pays Whom
₹350
You borrowed
₹430
You lent
Before
Hey, Vans!
Welcome back
Broke City
Pay back 7 friends
₹3150
Remind 5 friends
₹1630
After

It was difficult to locate the "Remind Now" button.

Lent and borrowed details

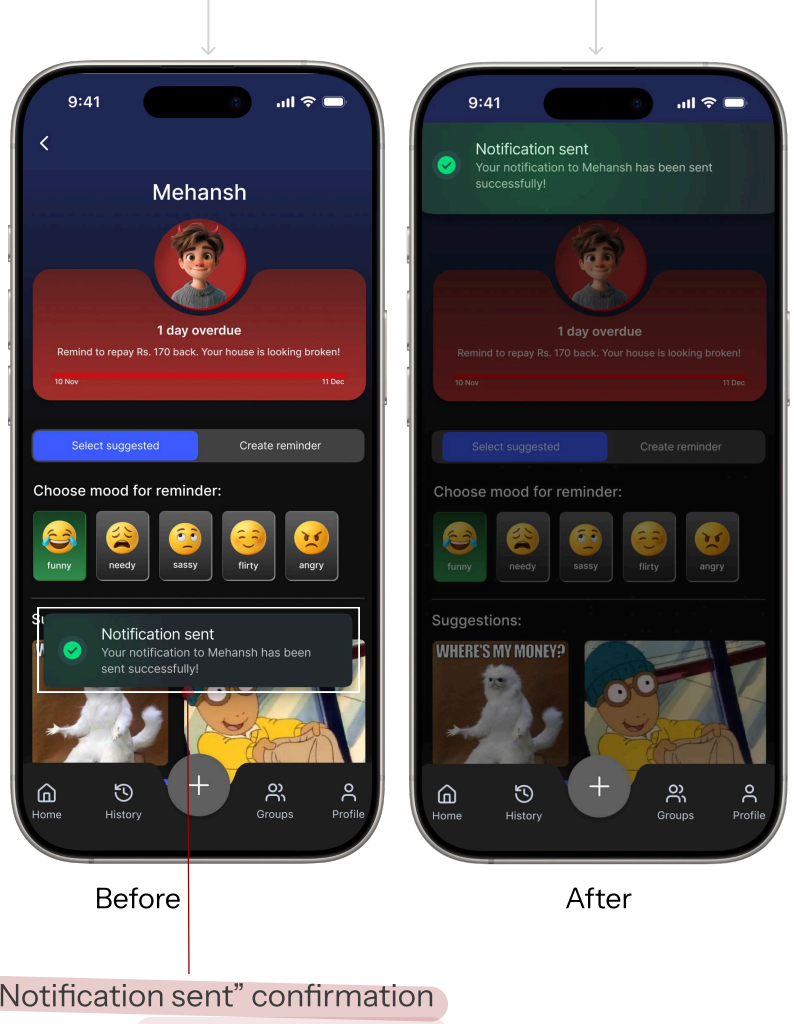
Screens show a quick overview of lent/borrowed details, with overdue entries highlighted in red.


Money you Lent others
₹457.00
Send reminder
Mehansh
Shrey
Vaibhavi
Riya
Money lent by you
Today
This Week
This Month
Mehansh
-₹157
Riya
-₹157
Rushabh
-₹157
Before
After

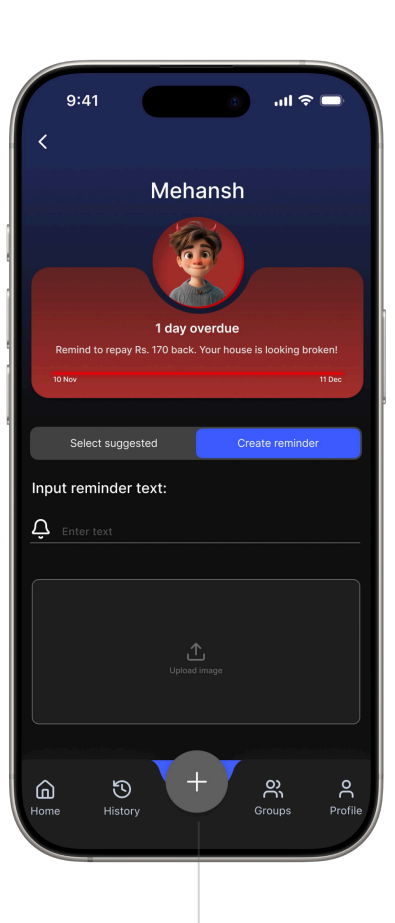
looked like its already selected

Reminder notifications

Personalised, emotion-based, notifications can be sent. Keeps the experience fun and light


Mehansh
1 day overdue
Select suggested
Create reminder
Choose mood for reminder:
funny
needy
sassy
flirty
angry
Notification sent
Your notification to Mehansh has been sent successfully!
Suggestions:
Before
After

"Notification sent" confirmation needs to be bolder

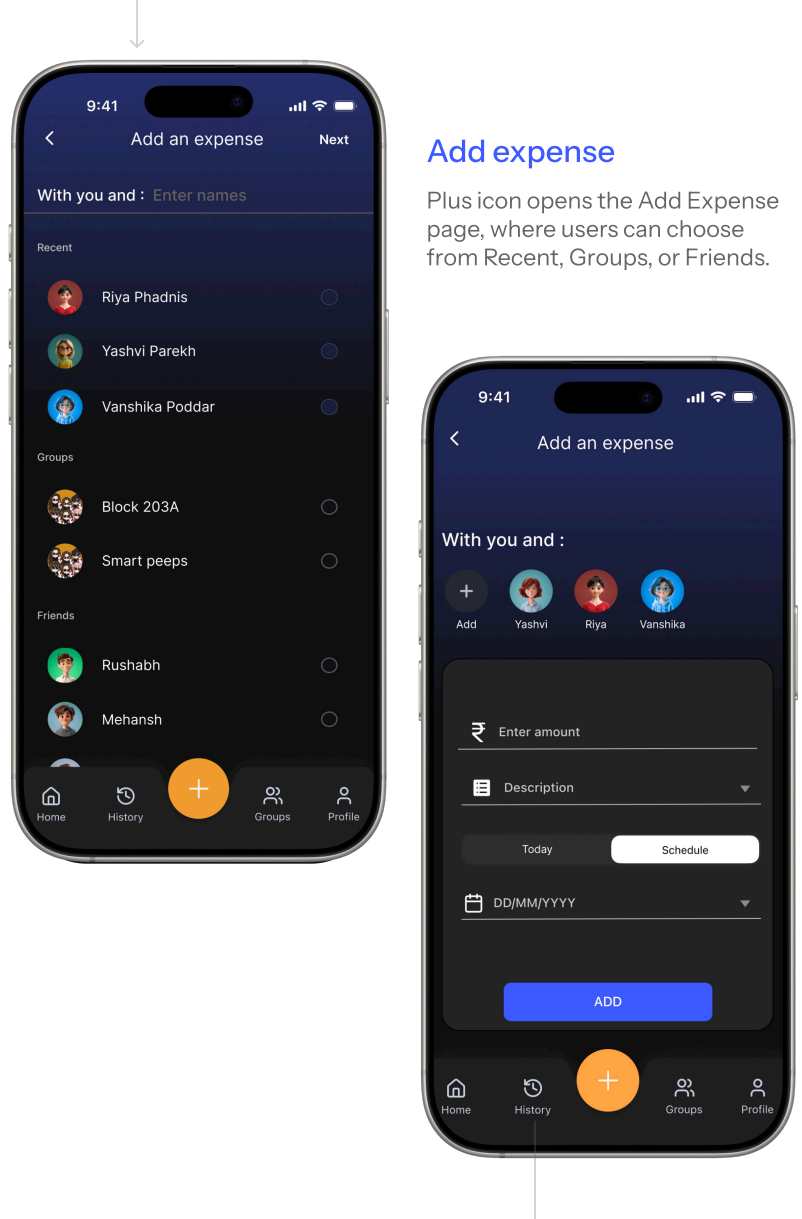

Mehansh
1 day overdue
Select suggested
Create reminder
Input reminder text:

Create Reminder

User can also create notification prompts based on personal preferences

Add expense

Plus icon opens the Add Expense page, where users can choose from Recent, Groups, or Friends.

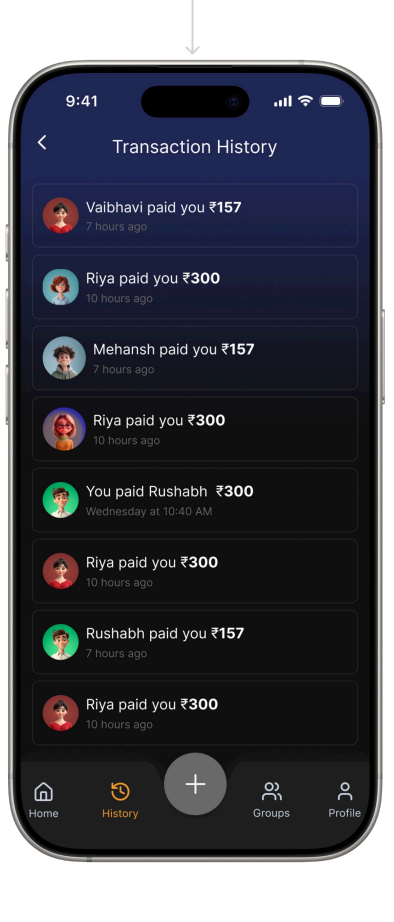

Add an expense
Next
With you and :
Recent
Riya Phadnis
Yashvi Parekh
Vanshika Poddar
Groups
Block 203A
Smart peeps
Friends
Rushabh
Mehansh
Enter amount
Description
Today
Schedule
DD/MM/YYYY
ADD

Add expense

Enter the amount and description, then choose to schedule the expense for today or a future date via the calendar.

Transaction history

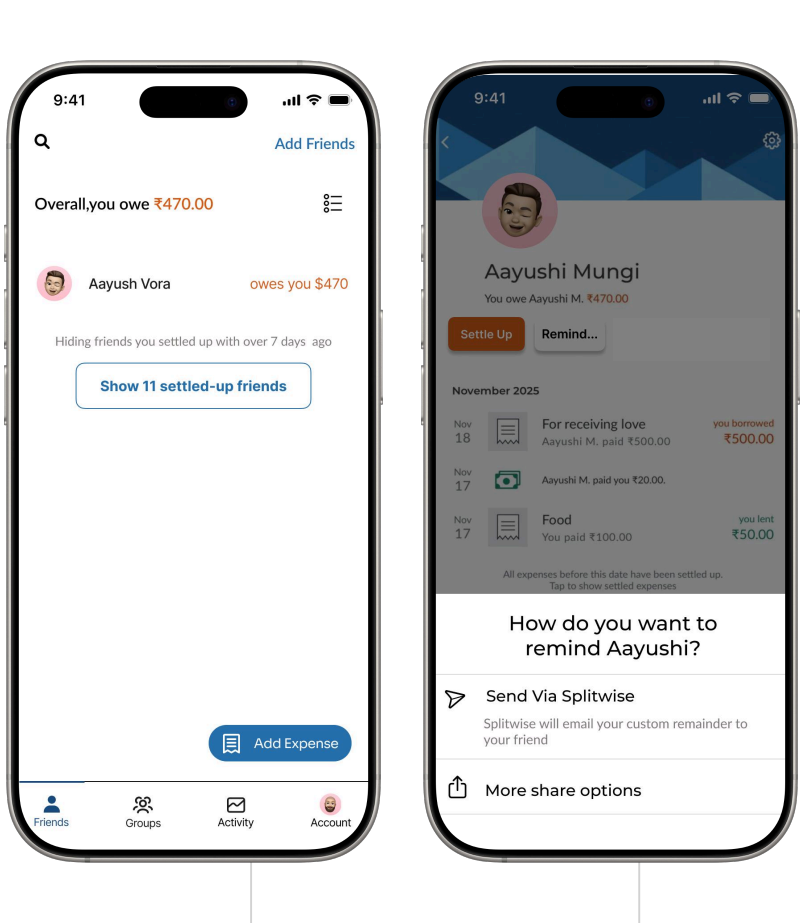
Shows transaction history for financial tracking ease.

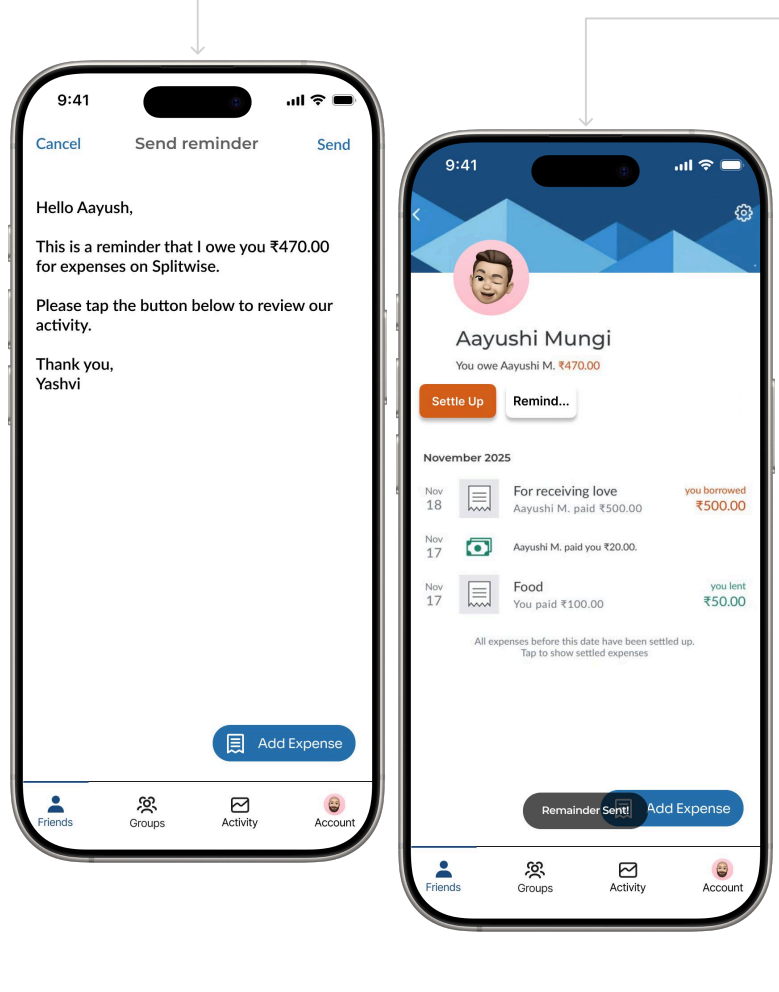

Transaction History

Vaibhavi paid you ₹157
Riya paid you ₹300
Mehansh paid you ₹157
Riya paid you ₹300
You paid Rushabh ₹300
Riya paid you ₹300
Rushabh paid you ₹157
Riya paid you ₹300

User Centred Interface *(SplitMoney)*

It represents the current market standard, a high-functioning, but emotionally neutral, solution.


Add Friends
Overall,you owe ₹470.00
Aayush Vora
owes you ₹470
Show 11 settled-up friends
Add Expense
Aayushi Mungi
Settle Up
Remind...
How do you want to remind Aayushi?
Send Via Splitwise
More share options


Cancel
Send reminder
Send
Add Expense
Aayushi Mungi
Settle Up
Remind...
Reminder Sent!

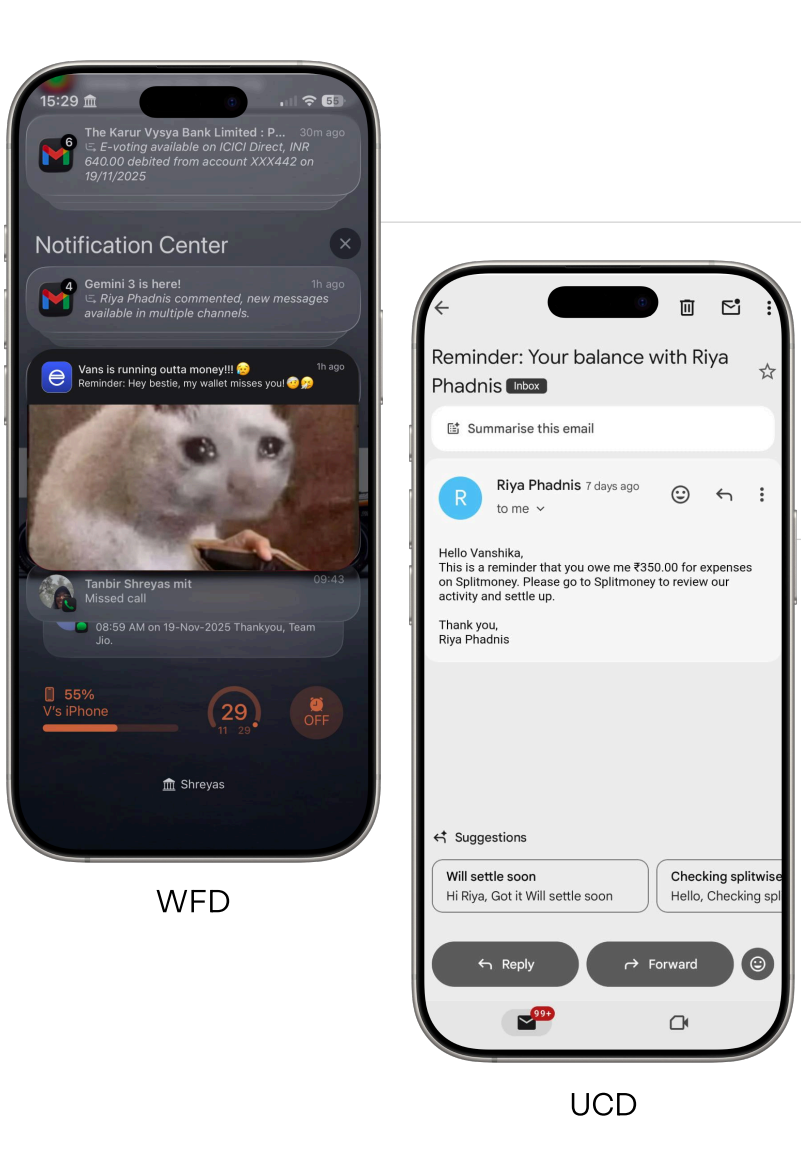
Hello Aayush,

This is a reminder that I owe you ₹470.00 for expenses on Splitwise.

Please tap the button below to review our activity.

Thank you,
Yashvi

Notifications recieved


Notification Center
WFD
UCD
Reply
Forward

Vans is running outta money!!!

Reminder: Your balance with Riya Phadnis

Hello Vanshika,
This is a reminder that you owe me ₹350.00 for expenses on Splitmoney. Please go to Splitmoney to review our activity and settle up.

Thank you,
Riya Phadnis

- Felt **calm, fun, and guilt-free**
- Successfully prompting **immediate positive repayment.**

- Too **formal/unwelcoming**
- Repayment was perceived as an **impersonal chore.**

Testing Insights

- **WFD succeeded in its primary goal:** shifting the user experience from a stressful financial transaction to a light-hearted experience.
- The **use of gamification acted as an effective emotional buffer**, reframed the stressful topic of debt into casual and engaging.
- **Minor Information Architecture changes** focusing on button discoverability and taskflow clarity needed.
- Summary of the borrowers and lenders on home screen would be incredibly helpful.

Contributions & Learnings

What I brought to the team

- Listening to the Silence: I dug into the survey data from our 34 participants and realized that the "awkwardness tax" wasn't just a phrase—it was a real social anxiety that kept friends from being honest with each other.
- Designing with Empathy: I championed the "Mood-Based Reminders" because I knew that sometimes a "funny" meme or a "sassy" nudge is the only way to ask for money without it feeling like a confrontation.
- Building a Visual Language: I helped create the "Broken House" gamification because I wanted to turn a stressful debt into a collaborative goal—helping a friend "fix" their space.
- Testing the Vibes: I led our A/B testing against standard apps like SplitMoney to see if users actually felt better using our "Worth Focused" approach versus a cold, clinical list of numbers.

What I'll take with me

- UX is more than utility: This project taught me that a "perfect" app isn't just one that works; it's one that understands the complicated, messy emotions people have about money.
- The power of a "How Might We": I learned that the best designs come from asking the right questions shifting our focus from "tracking debt" to "protecting friendships" changed everything.
- Collaboration is a "Co-Design": Using methods like Crazy 8s taught me that a team's best ideas are usually a mix of everyone's unique perspectives, and my job as a designer is to help synthesize those voices.

Thank you!